

Dartmouth Partners

A field guide to the recruitment firm that sits between London's boutique investment firms and the people they hire — how it makes money, how it screens, how it finds you on LinkedIn, and how to be the candidate it puts forward.

Written for someone with zero prior knowledge of the recruitment industry. Every term is defined on first use. Every claim is labelled by how well it is evidenced: **CONFIRMED** from the firm's own materials or public records, **REPORTED** from third parties and practitioner forums, and **INFERRED** from how the industry demonstrably works.

Subject: Dartmouth Partners Limited (UK company no. 05974472), part of Kernel Global | **Compiled:** 23 August 2026 | **Scope:** Business model · internal operations · sourcing & screening mechanics · LinkedIn discoverability · candidate playbook
Status: Independent research. Not affiliated with, endorsed by, or sourced from Dartmouth Partners. Not affiliated with Dartmouth College.

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How to use this document

You asked for the ins and outs — not the marketing copy. This guide is built in two halves. Parts I to IV explain the machine: what Dartmouth Partners sells, to whom, for how much, and what happens inside the firm between a client’s phone call and a candidate’s offer letter. Parts V and VI turn that understanding into actions you can take this week.

The confidence labels

Recruitment is a deliberately opaque industry. Firms publish polished summaries of their process and almost nothing about their internal mechanics. Rather than blur the line between fact and informed reconstruction, every substantive claim in this document carries one of three labels:

Label	Meaning
CONFIRMED	Stated by Dartmouth Partners or Kernel Global in their own published materials, or recorded in a public register (Companies House), or set out in legislation.
REPORTED	Asserted by identifiable third parties: press releases from investors, industry rankings, employee-review platforms, practitioner forums such as Wall Street Oasis. Useful, directionally reliable, individually unverifiable.
INFERRED	Not stated anywhere by Dartmouth, but a near-certain consequence of documented industry structure — how contingent recruitment fees work, how LinkedIn Recruiter functions, how a commission-driven desk behaves. Treat as a working model, not gospel.

ONE HONEST CAVEAT BEFORE YOU START

No one outside the firm has seen Dartmouth’s internal scorecards, its client fee agreements, or its consultant commission plan. Anyone who claims otherwise in a blog post is guessing. What *can* be established with precision is the shape of the machine, because the shape is dictated by economics and law that apply to every UK recruitment agency, and by a LinkedIn product whose behaviour is publicly documented. That shape is enough to give you the asymmetric advantage you are after.

If you only have twenty minutes

- 1 Read the Executive Summary (next page).
- 2 Read §4.2 — where candidates actually come from.
- 3 Read §5.3 and §5.4 — the Boolean searches being run, and the exact profile fields that decide whether you appear in them.
- 4 Work through Appendix B with your LinkedIn profile open in another window.
- 5 Register through the routes in Appendix A. Do it properly, once.

Executive summary

Twenty findings that change how you should think about Dartmouth Partners — and about every headhunter who messages you on LinkedIn.

- 1 Dartmouth Partners is a recruitment agency, not an employer and not a job board.** It is paid by hiring firms to find people. Founded as a trading brand in 2012, headquartered at 125 London Wall in the City, with offices in New York, Charlotte and Hong Kong. **CONFIRMED**
- 2 It sits inside a larger group.** Dartmouth is one of three brands under *Kernel Global*, alongside Pure Search (tax, legal, treasury, audit, compliance) and Catalyst Partners (HR). Kernel was built by Logan Naidu, who founded Dartmouth and remains Group CEO. Terri Loska is Dartmouth's CEO. **CONFIRMED**
- 3 It is private-equity backed itself.** Literacy Capital invested in 2018; Three Hills Capital Partners took a significant minority stake via a preferred instrument in March 2025. That matters to you: PE-backed recruiters run to growth targets, which means more outreach, more mandates, more desks — and pressure on consultants to convert. **CONFIRMED**
- 4 The group publishes its scale: 280+ employees, 900+ clients, a network of 260,000+ candidates.** Dartmouth alone says it screens *over 40,000 CVs a year* through its Early Careers operation. You are being processed at industrial volume. **CONFIRMED**
- 5 Their differentiator is a lifecycle strategy called “Classroom to Boardroom”.** Capture people as students and school-leavers, place them into internships and graduate roles, then re-place the same individuals every two to four years for the next thirty years. A student is not a low-value placement to them — a student is the beginning of an annuity. **CONFIRMED**
- 6 That is precisely why they message interns on LinkedIn.** Your value to a contingent recruiter is not only today's fee. It is the option on your next six moves, plus the day you become a hiring manager and call them with a mandate. **INFERRED**
- 7 Small and boutique investment firms use agencies because they have no internal recruiting function.** A 12-person fund has no talent-acquisition team, no employer brand, no campus presence and no time. It rents all four for a one-off fee. **INFERRED**
- 8 The standard UK fee is 15–30% of the hire's first-year base salary** — typically 17–20% for finance and accounting roles, and 20–30% for specialist, senior or hard-to-fill searches. On a £65,000 associate that is roughly £11,000–£19,500; on a £150,000 principal, £30,000–£45,000. **REPORTED**
- 9 You never pay a penny, and legally you cannot be charged.** The Employment Agencies Act 1973 and the Conduct of Employment Agencies and Employment Businesses Regulations 2003 prohibit charging a work-seeker a fee for finding them work. Any “recruiter” asking you for money to be put forward is breaking the law. **CONFIRMED**
- 10 Most contingent work is unpaid until someone starts.** The consultant does the mapping, the calls, the screening and the shortlist on spec. If the client hires elsewhere, the consultant earns nothing. This single fact explains almost every behaviour you will observe: the urgency, the chasing, the pressure to accept, the silence when you stop being placeable. **INFERRED**
- 11 They do publish a job board — but it is the minority of the business.** Their live board typically shows a few dozen roles across eleven sectors and a dozen cities. Sensitive buy-side mandates — the ones you actually want — are generally not advertised; they are run silently through the database and direct outreach. **CONFIRMED** / **INFERRED**

- 12 **The published candidate journey has six steps:** submit CV, meet a specialist consultant, sit skills and psychometric testing, interview with preparation and feedback, offer negotiation, then ongoing career support. The Early Careers version specifies English, Maths and psychometric assessments plus a client-side CV review. **CONFIRMED**
- 13 **The client-side promise is a “demanding pre-screening process” with technical and competency testing,** plus market mapping and benchmarking. Dartmouth refers to a “multi-layered proprietary screening platform”. Translation: they filter hard before a client ever sees your name, because a bad shortlist costs them the account. **CONFIRMED**
- 14 **Their privacy policy is the single most revealing public document about their back end.** It confirms they build candidate records from LinkedIn, corporate websites, job boards and CV libraries — without you applying — using “legitimate interests” as the lawful basis, and that they share data across Kernel Group brands. It also names their applicant-tracking system, *AppTracker*. **CONFIRMED**
- 15 **You have a legal right to see your own file.** A Subject Access Request to privacy@dartmouthpartners.com obliges them to disclose the personal data they hold on you, normally within one month. Very few candidates ever do this. Appendix D is a ready-to-send template. **CONFIRMED**
- 16 **LinkedIn Recruiter is the primary discovery tool, and it is a search engine you can optimise for.** It offers 40+ filters over roughly a billion profiles, with Boolean keyword search. Roughly nine in ten recruiter searches use the job-title field. Your title strings, location, employer names and skills are the index. **REPORTED**
- 17 **“Spotlights” decide who floats to the top of their results.** LinkedIn surfaces candidates who are open to work (privately, recruiter-only), who recently updated their profile, who follow or engage with the searcher’s company, who are connected to its employees, or whom the firm has contacted before. Four of those five are things you control. **CONFIRMED**
- 18 **Headhunters tier candidates on first contact, and the tier is sticky.** A screening call is a real interview. Firm, university, deal exposure, articulacy and seriousness get written into your record, and that record routes which mandates you are shown for years. **REPORTED**
- 19 **London buy-side hiring is off-cycle and lumpy, unlike US on-cycle.** The dense windows are September to early December and January to April, with processes running from three days to six weeks. Being in the database *before* a window opens is worth more than any application submitted during one. **REPORTED**
- 20 **No single agency covers the whole market, so a single relationship is a bad strategy.** Dartmouth is one of a handful of firms — alongside KEA Consultants, Blackwood, PER, Walker Hamill, Arkesden, Altus and others — that split London buy-side coverage between them, fund by fund, and the map changes yearly. **REPORTED**

What Dartmouth Partners actually is

The corporate anatomy, the ownership, the scale, and the five things people routinely mistake it for.

1.1 The one-paragraph answer

Dartmouth Partners is a specialist recruitment agency — a commercial intermediary whose entire product is *access to people*. Investment firms, banks, funds and corporates hire it to find, filter and deliver candidates for roles they need to fill. It is paid by those hiring firms, never by candidates. It was launched as a brand in 2012 by Logan Naidu, it specialises in financial and professional services — private equity, credit, M&A, senior finance, investor relations, public markets and adjacent fields — and it deliberately spans the entire career arc, from school-leaver apprenticeships through to chief financial officers. It is headquartered in the City of London with US and Asian offices, employs a few hundred people across its group, and is itself owned by its founder alongside private-equity investors.

THE MENTAL MODEL TO HOLD

Do not think of Dartmouth as a careers service that happens to charge companies. Think of it as a **market maker in a market with terrible information**. Funds cannot easily see which good people are quietly willing to move; good people cannot easily see which funds are quietly hiring. Dartmouth stands in the middle, holds both sets of information privately, and charges the side with money for a match. Everything else — the events, the compensation reports, the campus programmes, the LinkedIn outreach — exists to deepen the two piles of private information it sits on.

1.2 Corporate anatomy: Dartmouth, Kernel, Pure, Catalyst

Understanding the group structure explains behaviour you would otherwise find puzzling — such as why a consultant covering tax roles might have your CV, or why a firm that headhunts private-equity principals also runs school outreach programmes.

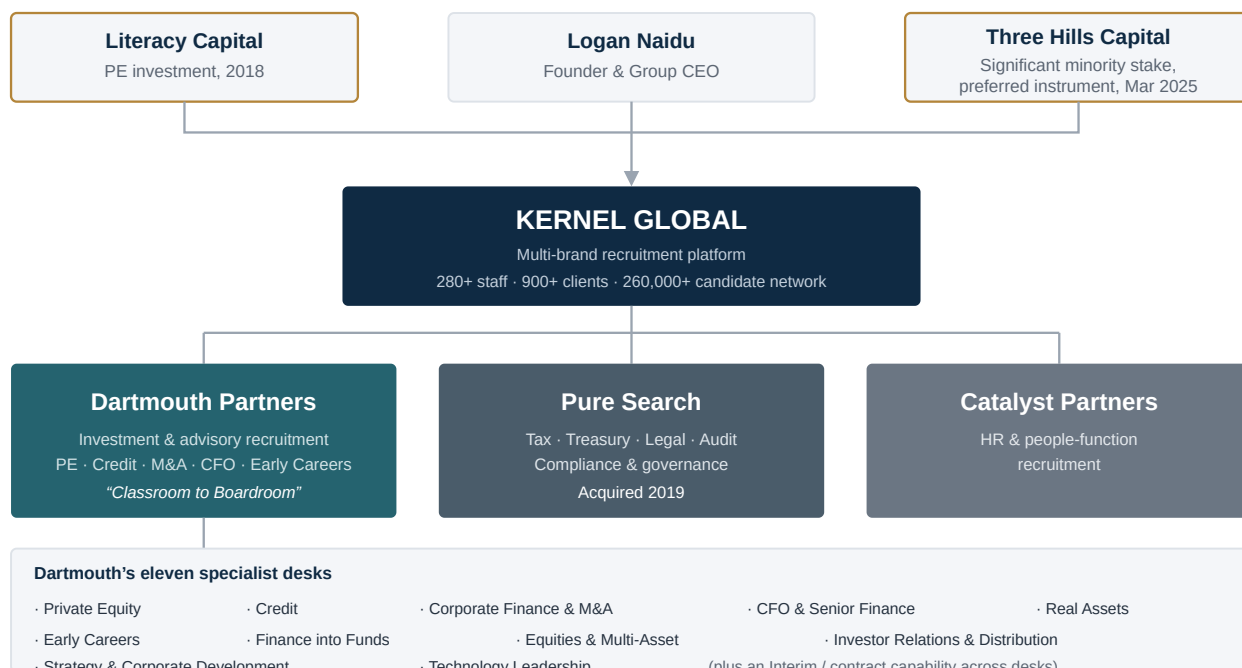


Figure 1 — Group structure. Dartmouth is the investment-and-advisory brand within Kernel Global. Candidate data is shared between Kernel companies where a specialist from another brand can help — a fact stated explicitly in Dartmouth's privacy policy. **CONFIRMED**

Why the group matters to you. Three practical consequences. First, if you register with Dartmouth you are, in effect, registering with a platform that also covers tax, legal, treasury, audit, compliance and HR — so a chartered accountant who tells Dartmouth they are open to industry may find a Pure Search consultant calling. Second, group-level growth targets flow down to desk-level activity targets, which is why outreach volume is high. Third, the group can afford things a small agency cannot: proprietary compensation research, a global events series, a charitable foundation, campus teams. Those are candidate-acquisition assets. When you attend one of their events, you are entering the database.

1.3 Timeline: 2005 to 2026



Note: the legal entity Dartmouth Partners Limited (no. 05974472) shows an incorporation date of 23 October 2006 at Companies House — consistent with a pre-existing company being renamed and used for the 2012 brand launch. The trading brand dates from 2012.

Figure 2 — Two decades in one line. The pattern to notice: a founder-led specialist agency that took institutional capital twice and used it to buy adjacent brands and open overseas offices. **CONFIRMED** / **REPORTED**

1.4 Scale, offices and the numbers they publish

280+EMPLOYEES
ACROSS KERNEL
GLOBAL**900+**CLIENT
COMPANIES
SERVED**260,000+**CANDIDATES IN
THE NETWORK**40,000+**CVS SCREENED
PER YEAR, EARLY
CAREERS ALONE**11**SPECIALIST
SECTOR DESKS AT
DARTMOUTH**4**

OFFICES: LONDON, NEW YORK, CHARLOTTE, HONG KONG

Public markers of scale and standing, with the source and what it does and does not prove.

Marker	Detail	Confidence
Registered office	125 London Wall, London EC2Y 5AS — a City of London address a short walk from Moorgate, in the same square mile as most of their clients.	CONFIRMED
Legal entity	Dartmouth Partners Limited, company no. 05974472. SIC code 78109, “other activities of employment placement agencies”. Active; accounts filed to 31 December 2025.	CONFIRMED
Team page	Roughly 100+ named individuals on Dartmouth’s own site, with a ladder running Associate → Consultant → Senior Consultant → Principal → Associate Director → Director → Executive Director → Managing Director.	CONFIRMED
Leadership	Terri Loska (CEO, Dartmouth), Logan Naidu (Group CEO & Founder, Kernel), Darren Sookramanien (Group CFO), Will Lambeth (Head of London, PE background).	CONFIRMED
Growth recognition	Sunday Times 100 fastest-growing private companies (#33 in the 2022 list, three-year CAGR reported near 96%); FT ranking of Europe’s fastest-growing companies; FT UK Leading Recruiters; Recruiter Hot 100.	REPORTED
Candidate-side standing	Placed #10 among UK recruiters overall and #3 for investment banking in eFinancialCareers’ Ideal Recruiter 2024–25 rankings.	REPORTED
Diversity claim	54% female placements into private equity portfolio roles, cited in the 2025 Three Hills announcement. Sister brand Pure claims 30% of sitting FTSE 100 Heads of Tax.	REPORTED
Revenue	Third-party data aggregators publish wildly inconsistent figures (one shows £19m with a 46% year-on-year fall; another shows c.\$53m). <i>Treat all of them as unreliable.</i> Use Companies House filings directly if you need a real number.	REPORTED

1.5 What Dartmouth is *not*

Five misconceptions, each of which leads candidates to behave badly.

- 1 Not connected to Dartmouth College.** The name is a City naming convention — Naidu’s earlier firm was “The Cornell Partnership”. Ivy-League-sounding names are a deliberate branding trope in UK financial recruitment. There is no academic affiliation.

- 2 **Not your employer, and not your agent.** When they place you, you sign a contract with the client, not with Dartmouth. Their contractual and commercial duty runs to the fee-payer. Their *interest* in you is real but conditional: it lasts exactly as long as you are placeable. This is not cynicism, it is structure — and knowing it lets you use them correctly instead of feeling betrayed by them.
- 3 **Not a pure executive-search house.** Classic executive search (Heidrick & Struggles, Egon Zehnder, Spencer Stuart) is retained-only, board-level, and paid in thirds regardless of outcome. Dartmouth does offer retained and executive solutions, but the bulk of its volume — certainly at analyst and associate level — is contingent: no placement, no fee. The economics of contingency drive everything you will experience.
- 4 **Not a careers service.** The CV workshops, mock interviews, compensation reports and student network are genuine and useful, and they are also the top of a funnel. Take the help. Understand why it is free.
- 5 **Not a monopoly gatekeeper.** Coverage in London is split across a dozen firms, fund by fund and often mandate by mandate. Dartmouth cannot show you a role it does not hold. Anyone who tells you a single headhunter relationship is sufficient is either lazy or selling something.

The business model: who pays, and why

Follow the money and every behaviour becomes predictable — the outreach, the urgency, the chasing, the silence.

2.1 The two-sided market

Dartmouth operates a classic two-sided market. On one side sit **clients**: private equity funds, credit funds, investment banks, asset managers, PE-backed portfolio companies and corporates. On the other sit **candidates**. Value flows both ways, but cash flows only one way.

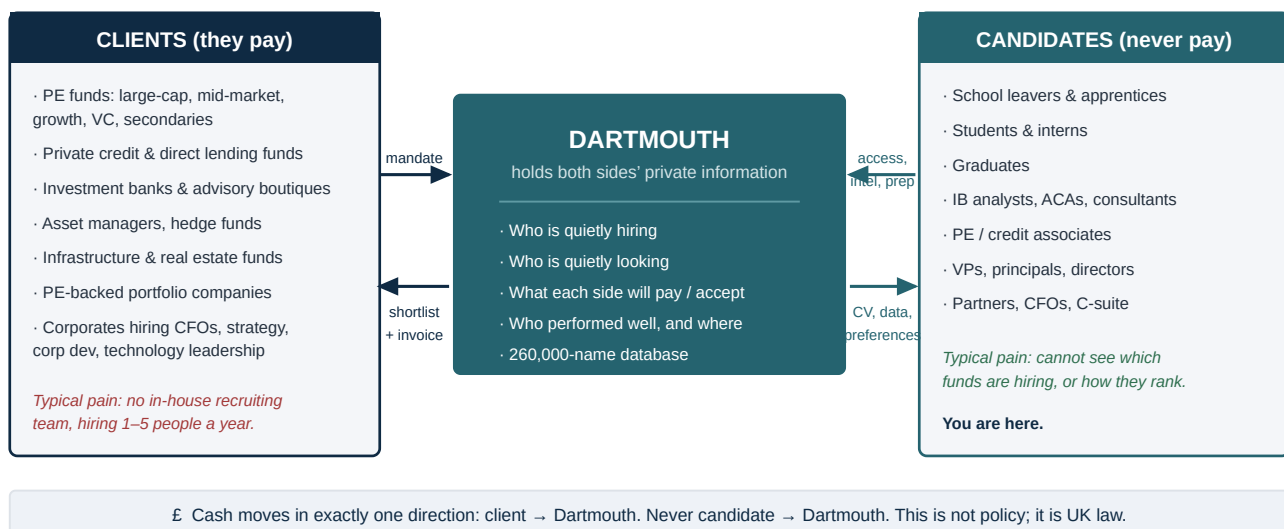


Figure 3 — The two-sided market. You are not the customer. You are the inventory *and* a future customer — which is why the good firms treat candidates well anyway. **INFERRED STRUCTURE**, **CONFIRMED INPUTS**

2.2 Contingent, retained, interim: the three ways they get paid

Dartmouth publicly offers permanent, interim, executive, retained and succession services. Those collapse into three commercial models, and it is worth knowing which one you are inside, because it changes how hard the consultant will work for you and how much control they have.

Model	How it works	What it means for you
Contingent The default for analyst → VP	No fee unless a candidate the agency introduced is hired and starts. Often several agencies compete on the same role. Fee is a percentage of first-year base salary, invoiced on start date, payable typically within 7–30 days, with a rebate if you leave early.	Speed is everything. The consultant is racing rivals and racing the client's own direct applicants. Expect fast turnarounds, pressure to say yes, and a strong preference for candidates who are decisive and interview-ready <i>now</i> .
Retained / executive Senior, confidential, or scarce	Client pays in instalments — classically a third on engagement, a third on shortlist delivery, a third on placement — regardless of outcome. The agency is exclusive.	Slower, more thorough, more honest. A retained consultant will spend real time with you because they are paid to run a proper process, and they have no rival agency to beat. If you are told a search is retained and exclusive, the consultant genuinely controls access.
Interim / contract Cover, projects, transformations	The agency acts as an <i>employment business</i> : it may pay the worker itself and bill the client a day rate with a margin on top, or introduce a contractor for a placement fee. IR35 status and right-to-work checks sit here — which is why their privacy policy collects NI numbers, bank details and payroll data.	Different rules apply: you may be paid by Dartmouth rather than the client, and you should always know your margin, your rate, and your IR35 determination before signing.

2.3 A worked fee example, end to end

Say a mid-market private equity fund needs one associate. It calls three agencies, Dartmouth among them, on a contingent basis. Dartmouth maps the market, contacts perhaps sixty relevant people, screens fifteen, submits four, and one is hired at a base salary of £90,000.

Illustrative agency fee by seniority (UK market norms, first-year base salary basis)

Graduate / apprentice £35,000 base @ ~15%	£5,250
IB analyst £60,000 base @ ~18%	£10,800
PE associate £90,000 base @ ~20%	£18,000
Credit VP £150,000 base @ ~22.5%	£33,750
CFO (retained) £250,000 base @ ~27.5%	£68,750

What happens after the offer is signed

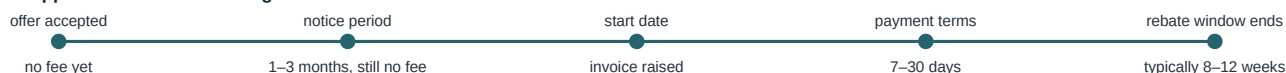


Figure 4 — Fee scale and cash timing. Percentages are UK market norms, not Dartmouth's published rates, which are commercially confidential and negotiated per client. Note how long the agency waits for cash: a placement agreed in March may not be paid until July, and can be clawed back until September. **REPORTED NORMS** **ILLUSTRATIVE FIGURES**

THE THREE CONSEQUENCES YOU CAN ACTUALLY USE

1. Your base salary is their revenue line. A consultant negotiating your offer upward is not being kind; they are being paid more. This is the rare moment when your interests and theirs align almost perfectly. Use them hard at the offer stage.

2. The rebate makes them care whether you stay. If you resign in week six, the agency may have to refund part or all of the fee. That is why a good consultant will push back on a bad fit — and why they will call you a month after you start.

3. Early-career placements are low-fee, high-volume. A £5,000 fee cannot support a bespoke, hand-held search. Early Careers is therefore a *process* business: standardised tests, batch screening, 40,000 CVs a year. Being memorable inside a batch process requires different tactics than being memorable in a bespoke one — see §6.1.

2.4 Why a 12-person fund pays £30,000 to hire one associate

This is the question you asked most directly: *why do small boutique firms use Dartmouth?* The answer is a build-versus-buy calculation that almost always resolves the same way.

What hiring requires	If the fund does it in-house	If it hires Dartmouth
Knowing who exists	Someone must map every analyst at 30 banks and every associate at 40 funds, by hand, and keep it current.	Already mapped, already in a 260,000-name database, refreshed continuously by eleven desks.
Reaching passive people	A partner cold-messaging analysts signals desperation and leaks the mandate to the market.	An agency can approach anyone without revealing the fund's name until it chooses to.
Confidentiality	Advertising “we are hiring an associate” tells LPs, competitors and your existing team things you may not want known — especially if the hire is a replacement.	Blind mandates are standard. This is a major, underappreciated reason boutiques use agencies.
Filtering	Partners bill their time at deal-team rates. Reading 300 CVs is the most expensive screening in the world.	Screening is the agency's core cost, amortised across many clients.
Benchmarking	A fund hiring once a year has no idea what the market pays this quarter.	Dartmouth publishes compensation reports across PE, credit, infrastructure, equities, IB and early careers, drawn from hundreds of practitioner conversations.
Risk	A failed hire in a 12-person fund is catastrophic and consumes a year.	Rebate periods transfer part of that risk back to the agency.
Cost	An in-house recruiter costs £70k–£120k fully loaded, every year, whether or not you hire.	£18k–£35k, once, only if a hire actually starts.

Run the arithmetic. A boutique hiring two people a year would pay roughly £36,000–£70,000 in agency fees. An in-house recruiter capable of running buy-side searches costs more than that and sits idle ten months of the year. Below roughly ten to fifteen hires a year, buying is simply cheaper than building — which is exactly the range most boutique funds occupy.

Large banks, by contrast, cross that threshold easily, which is why they run enormous internal talent-acquisition teams and use agencies only for niche or senior roles. INFERRED

THE ASYMMETRY HIDING IN THAT TABLE

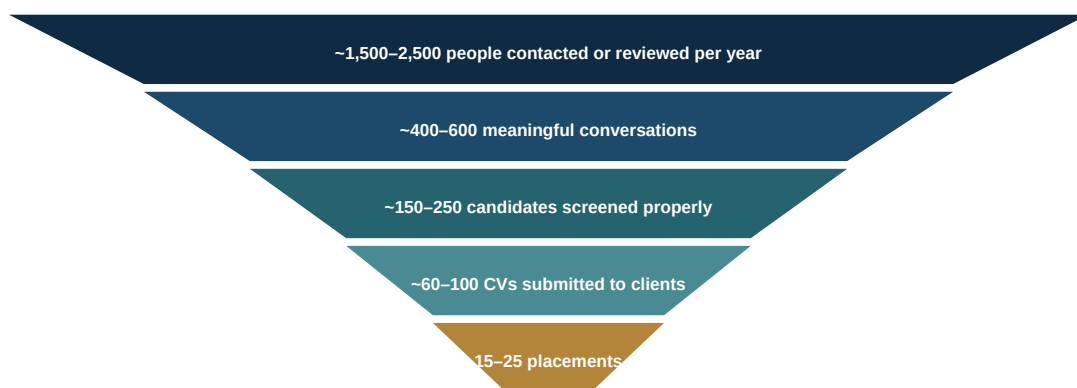
The reason funds pay is *information*, not labour. If you make yourself **legible and reachable** — easy to find, easy to categorise, easy to represent — you make the agency’s product cheaper to produce. Consultants systematically over-represent candidates who are cheap to represent: whose CV needs no explanation, whose motivations are clear, who answer within an hour, who have no messy gaps to justify. That is the whole game, and it is almost entirely within your control.

2.5 Desk economics — and what they mean for you

Dartmouth does not publish consultant targets, and the numbers below are an industry-standard reconstruction rather than internal data. But the shape is reliable, and the shape is what determines whether your email gets answered.

INFERRED THROUGHOUT

The funnel a single mid-level consultant runs to bill one year’s target



Implied ratios: roughly 1 placement per 100 people touched; roughly 1 in 4 submitted CVs converts. At an average fee of £15,000–£20,000, 15–25 placements is £250,000–£450,000 of annual billings — a normal target for an established consultant on a specialist desk.

Figure 5 — Why they message so many people. The maths forces high-volume outreach. It also explains why a non-reply is rarely personal: at the top of that funnel, you were one of two thousand. INFERRED

Four behavioural predictions fall out of this funnel, and you will observe every one of them:

- **Response speed is triaged by placeability, not politeness.** A consultant with a live mandate you fit will answer in minutes. The same person will leave a thoughtful message unanswered for three weeks if you fit nothing currently open. This is queue management, not rudeness.
- **They prefer candidates already in process elsewhere.** A candidate with two competing offers proves the market values them and creates urgency with the client. Mentioning (truthfully) that you are in another process raises your internal priority.
- **They will ask where else you have applied — and there is a reason.** If another agency already submitted you to a fund, Dartmouth cannot claim the fee for that introduction. “Ownership” of a candidate-client pairing is contractual and time-limited. Answer honestly; it protects you as much as them.
- **Consultants change desks and firms often.** Recruitment has high turnover. The person who owns your relationship may be gone in eighteen months, which is why you should maintain a relationship with the *firm* (registered, in the database, on the events list), not only with one individual.

2.6 The legal floor: it is free for you, by statute

UK recruitment operates under the Employment Agencies Act 1973 and the Conduct of Employment Agencies and Employment Businesses Regulations 2003, enforced by the Employment Agency Standards Inspectorate. The provisions worth knowing: **CONFIRMED**

- **No fees to work-seekers.** An agency must not charge you for finding or attempting to find you work. The narrow statutory exceptions concern entertainment and modelling, not finance. Optional extra services such as CV writing may be charged for, but must be genuinely optional and separately agreed — and no agency may make finding you work conditional on buying them.
- **The fee is a business-to-business matter.** The Regulations do not cap what agencies charge employers; that is a commercial negotiation. So there is no published rate card and never will be.
- **Terms must be agreed with you in writing** before the agency acts for you, including whether they are acting as an employment agency (permanent) or employment business (temporary/interim).
- **You cannot be charged for, or penalised for, refusing a role.** Pressure to accept is a sales tactic, not an obligation.

IF SOMETHING FEELS WRONG

Two escalation routes exist and both are free. For data issues — being contacted about roles you never asked for, or wanting to see and correct your file — use UK GDPR rights and complain to the Information Commissioner's Office. For conduct issues — fees demanded, your CV sent somewhere without permission, misleading role descriptions — the Employment Agency Standards Inspectorate is the regulator. Sending your CV to a client *without your consent* is a genuine breach, not a grey area, and it is worth telling any agency early and politely that you expect to approve every submission by name.

The eleven desks and where you fit

Dartmouth is not one business. It is eleven specialist desks sharing a brand, a database and a floor. Talking to the wrong one wastes a first impression you only get once.

3.1 Sector map

The eleven published desks, what each sells, and the candidate profile it buys.

DESKS AND ROLE TYPES CONFIRMED

PROFILE COLUMN INFERRED FROM ROLE TYPES

Desk	Roles it fills	Who it recruits
Private Equity	Associate, Senior Associate, Principal, Partner; portfolio/operations executives; origination directors. Large-cap, mid-market, growth, VC and secondaries funds.	Investment-banking analysts, strategy consultants, existing PE associates, occasionally Big Four transaction-services and corporate-finance people.
Credit	Private credit and direct lending: analyst to director, across origination, underwriting and portfolio management.	Leveraged finance and DCM analysts, restructuring bankers, credit-fund associates, ratings-agency analysts.
Corporate Finance & M&A	Advisory and in-house M&A: analyst through director, at banks, boutiques and corporates.	Bankers moving bank-to-bank, corporate-development professionals, ACAs from corporate finance.
CFO & Senior Finance	CFO, finance director, financial controller, group reporting, FP&A leadership — heavily into PE-backed portfolio companies.	Qualified accountants (ACA/ACCA/CIMA) with five to twenty-five years' experience.
Finance into Funds	The in-house finance function of <i>the fund itself</i> : fund controller, head of fund finance, EMEA financial controller, FP&A director, fund CFO.	Mid-to-senior finance professionals with fund or alternatives experience. The classic destination for audit and fund-administration accountants.
Investor Relations & Distribution	Fundraising, LP relations, product specialists, capital formation, marketing and distribution inside funds.	Ex-bankers, ex-consultants, placement-agent staff, and increasingly ACAs pivoting out of audit into commercial fund roles.
Equities & Multi-Asset	Public-markets investment roles: research analysts, portfolio managers, multi-asset and long-only investment professionals.	Sell-side equity research, buy-side analysts, hedge-fund analysts.
Real Assets	Infrastructure, real estate, energy and renewables investment teams: analyst to director, plus asset management.	Infra bankers, project-finance specialists, engineers with finance training, existing real-asset investors.
Strategy & Corporate Development	In-house strategy, corporate development and transformation, largely at corporates and PE-backed businesses.	Management consultants (MBB and Big Four strategy houses), bankers moving in-house.
Technology Leadership	CTO, CIO, CPO, head of engineering and digital-transformation leadership in financial services and PE portfolios.	Senior technologists; not an early-career route.
Early Careers	Apprenticeships, insight days, work experience (one day to two weeks), internships and graduate roles,	Students, school leavers, penultimate- and final-year undergraduates, and recent graduates. If you are currently an intern, this is your desk.

across banks, funds, asset
managers, corporates and start-ups.

3.2 Which desk owns you, by career stage

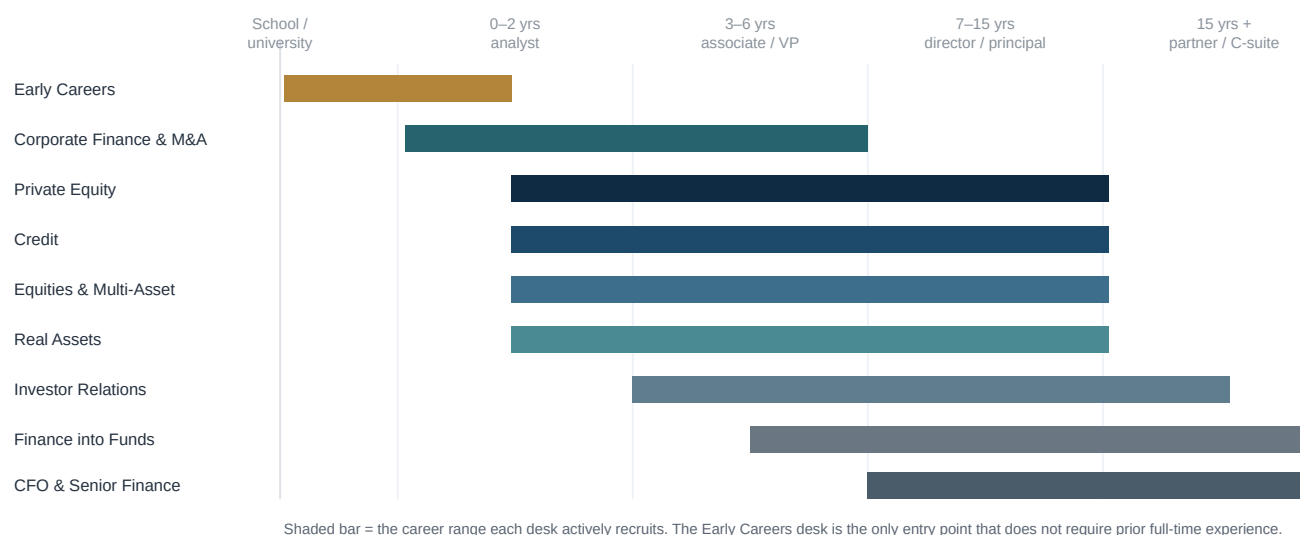


Figure 6 — Desk coverage by seniority. Note the handover: Early Careers places you into your first role, then hands you — and your record — to a sector desk two or three years later. That handover *is* the Classroom-to-Boardroom model.

INFERRED MAPPING FROM PUBLISHED ROLE TYPES

PRACTICAL ROUTING RULE

Contact the desk that matches **where you will be in twelve months**, not where you are today — but register with the desk that matches where you are today. If you are an intern heading into a graduate role, Early Careers is your registration point (earlycareers@dartmouthpartners.com). If you are a first-year analyst hoping to move to a fund, the Private Equity or Credit desk is the one to build a relationship with now, because they will be running the mandates you want in eighteen months. Sending the same email to all eleven inboxes marks you as unfocused and gets filed as such.

The back end: what actually happens

From the client's phone call to the invoice, and everything the candidate never sees — the database record, the screening stack, and the incentives driving both.

4.1 The mandate pipeline, stage by stage

Every placement follows the same twelve-stage arc. Dartmouth's own published client process — consultation, tailored search strategy, network access, demanding pre-screening with technical and competency testing, interview management, feedback, offer negotiation, onboarding support, ongoing partnership — is this arc, described from the client's side.

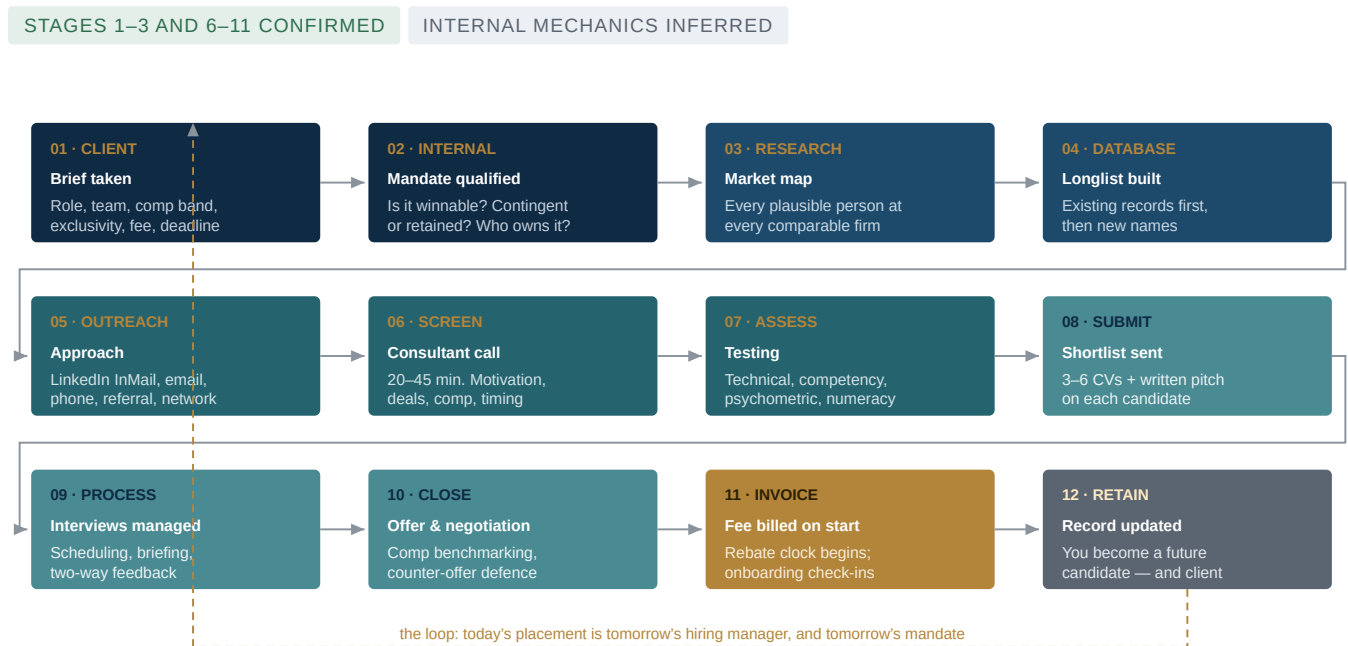


Figure 7 — The twelve-stage mandate pipeline. Candidates only ever see stages 5 to 10. The commercially decisive stages are 1, 2 and 4 — all of which happen before you know the role exists. Being in the database at stage 4 is the entire objective.

The same twelve stages, with realistic timings and the single highest-value action available to you at each.

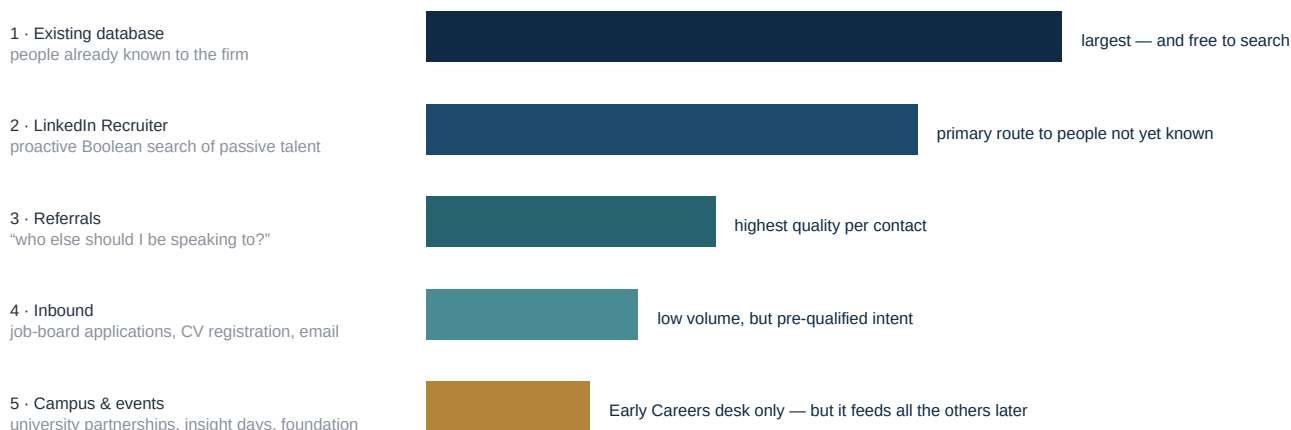
TIMINGS ARE TYPICAL RANGES, NOT DARTMOUTH'S PUBLISHED SLAS

#	Stage	Typical duration	What you can do about it
1	Client brief taken	1 call, 30–60 min	Nothing directly — but a consultant who already knows you will think of you <i>during</i> this call. That is the whole value of being known early.
2	Mandate qualified internally	Same day	Nothing.
3	Market map / search strategy	1–5 days	Be findable. Your LinkedIn title, employer and location decide whether you appear in the map at all. See Part V.
4	Longlist built from database first	Hours	Be <i>in</i> the database, correctly tagged, with a current CV. This is the cheapest, most neglected action in the whole process.
5	Outreach	2–10 days	Reply within hours, even to say “not now, but here is my situation”. Non-repliers get re-tagged as unresponsive.
6	Consultant screening call	20–45 min	Treat it as a real interview. It is the stage where your permanent tier is set. See §6.2.
7	Testing	30 min–3 hrs	For early careers: numerical, verbal and psychometric. For investment roles: technical and competency assessment. Practise numerical reasoning before you need it.
8	Shortlist submitted	Same week	Give the consultant the raw material for their written pitch — three sharp lines on why you fit <i>this</i> fund. Many will use your wording verbatim.
9	Interviews	3 days–6 weeks	Demand the briefing. Ask who you are meeting, what they test, whether there is a modelling test or case study, and what previous candidates got wrong. They know, and they will tell you.
10	Offer and negotiation	2–10 days	Let them negotiate. Their fee rises with your base. Be explicit about your number early so they can position it.
11	Start date, invoice, rebate window	1–3 months later	Answer their check-in calls. A consultant whose placement went well will move you again in three years.
12	Record updated, relationship retained	Ongoing	Update them when you change role or get promoted. Two emails a year keeps your record live and correctly tiered.

4.2 Where candidates come from: the five sourcing channels

When a consultant needs twenty plausible names by Friday, they draw from five pools in a predictable order of cost. Cheapest first, always.

Relative weight of sourcing channels on a specialist finance desk (illustrative)



Proportions are an industry-typical illustration, not Dartmouth data. The ordering — database first, paid search second, referrals third — is near-universal because it tracks cost per name.

Figure 8 — Channel mix. The two channels you can directly influence are #1 (register, and keep your record fresh) and #2 (be searchable). Channel #3 — referrals — is influenced indirectly: be the person other candidates name. **INFERRED**

WHY THIS ORDERING IS THE SINGLE MOST USEFUL FACT IN THIS DOCUMENT

A consultant with a live mandate searches their own database *first*, because it costs nothing and the records already contain salary, motivation and quality notes that LinkedIn cannot show. Only when the database is thin do they open LinkedIn Recruiter and start paying for InMails and cold conversations.

Which means: **the candidate who registered eight months ago, uploaded a clean CV, had a twenty-minute call and updated their record when they changed teams is structurally ahead of an identical candidate who is merely findable on LinkedIn.** Everyone optimises LinkedIn. Almost nobody optimises being in the database properly. Do both.

4.3 The database is the asset — what is in your record

Kernel Global publishes a candidate network figure of 260,000+. That database, not the office or the brand, is the firm's balance sheet. Dartmouth's privacy policy is unusually informative about what sits inside it, and it is the closest thing to a public description of their back end that exists.

CONFIRMED — ALL ITEMS BELOW ARE DRAWN FROM THEIR PUBLISHED PRIVACY POLICY

Category	What they record
Identity & contact	Name, address, email, telephone, date of birth, gender, next of kin.
Professional	CV, photograph, LinkedIn profile and other public professional profiles, qualifications and their verification.
Compliance	Right-to-work documentation, IR35 status, criminal-record checks where lawful.
Payroll (interim/temp)	National Insurance number, bank details, payroll records, tax status.
Special category	Diversity data and health information — explicit consent only.
Behavioural	Website interactions, IP address, browser data, event registrations, survey responses.

WHERE THE DATA COMES FROM — INCLUDING WHEN YOU NEVER APPLIED

The policy states plainly that personal data is collected not only from you directly (website applications through their *AppTracker* system, CV submissions, account creation, event registration, surveys) but also from third parties: **“LinkedIn, corporate websites, job board websites, online CV libraries”** and personal recommendations. Where data comes from a third party they undertake to notify you within thirty days. The lawful basis is primarily **legitimate interests** — identifying relevant candidates — not consent.

This is the mechanical answer to your question about colleagues being contacted out of the blue. They did not opt in. A researcher or consultant found them by name and employer, built a record, and approached them. It is lawful, standard across the industry, and it is why a strong public profile functions as a permanent, passive application to every search firm in London.

WHO ELSE SEES IT

The policy discloses sharing with: other Kernel Group companies, prospective employers and clients, job boards, payroll providers, identity-verification companies, insurers, analytics and advertising networks, sub-contractors, and — notably — prospective buyers of the business. International transfers outside the UK/EEA are made under Standard Contractual Clauses or an International Data Transfer Agreement.

RETENTION

No fixed period is published. Retention is described as depending on contractual and legal obligations, legitimate business interests, potential disputes and regulator guidance, with a separate retention notice available on request. Records may be archived, kept on financial systems only, or deleted from the CRM. In practice, assume that **a record created about you today will still exist in some form in five years.**

THE LEVER ALMOST NOBODY PULLS

Under UK GDPR you can submit a **Subject Access Request** and require them to disclose the personal data they hold about you — normally within one month, free. In practice this can surface the consultant notes and categorisations attached to your record: how you were described, which mandates you were considered for, what salary and motivation were logged. You also have rights to rectification (fix a wrong salary or job title in your record), objection to processing based on legitimate interests, restriction, portability, and complaint to the ICO.

Two caveats: they may lawfully redact information that would reveal third parties — including client identities and, sometimes, consultants’ personal opinions where these are intertwined with others’ data. And filing an SAR does mark you out. It is a tool for correcting a record you believe is wrong or stale, not a routine move. Template in Appendix D; address it to privacy@dartmouthpartners.com or privacy@kernel-global.com.

4.4 The screening stack

Dartmouth tells clients it runs a “demanding pre-screening process” with technical and competency testing, and describes a “multi-layered proprietary screening platform” supported by detailed market mapping. Its Early Careers process specifies English, Maths and psychometric assessment, followed by a client-side CV review. Put together with how agency screening universally works, the stack looks like this.

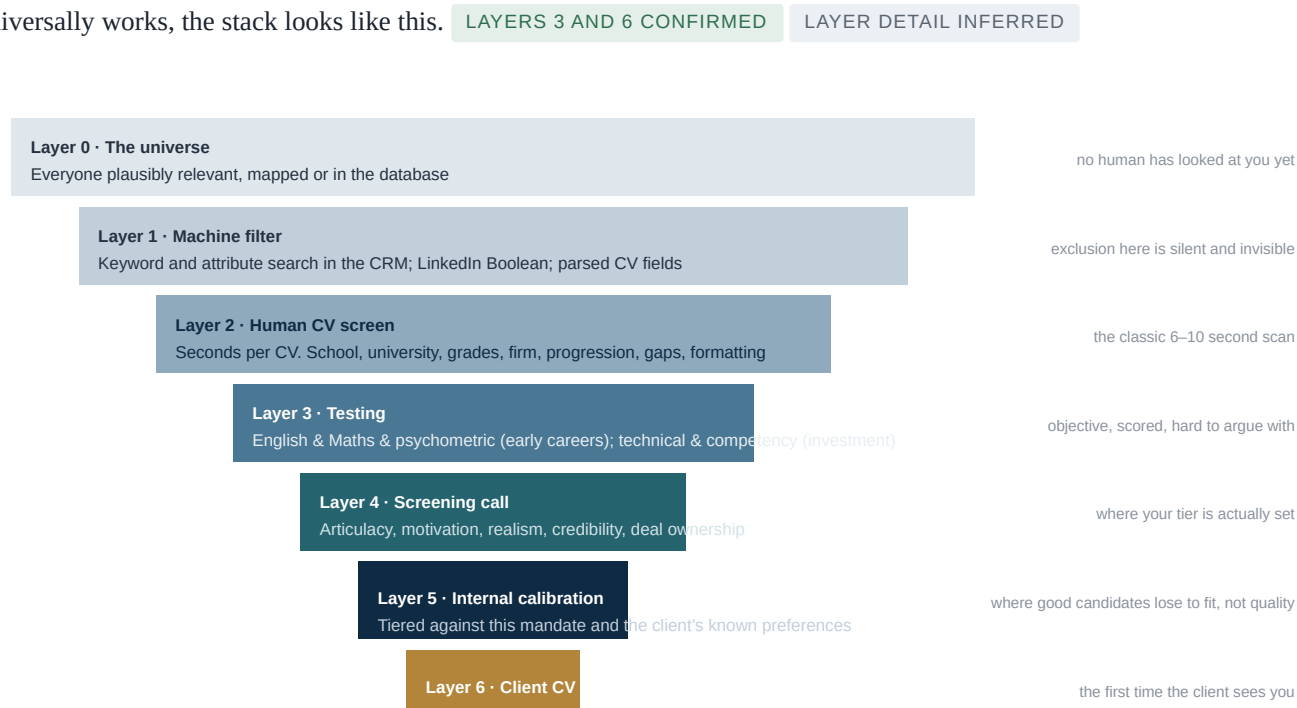


Figure 9 — Six filters before a client reads your name. Four of the six are invisible to you. The two you can prepare for — testing and the screening call — are the two most candidates treat casually.

WHAT EACH LAYER IS REALLY TESTING

- **Layer 1 (machine).** Whether your record contains the literal strings a consultant types. “M&A” is not “Mergers and Acquisitions” to a naive keyword search; “Summer Analyst” is not “Intern”. Redundancy in your own wording is free insurance — write both forms somewhere in your CV and profile.
- **Layer 2 (CV scan).** In finance recruitment the scan looks for a small number of hard tokens: university and degree class, A-levels or equivalent (still routinely asked for at junior level in the UK), employer names, exact dates, promotion velocity, and deal or project names. Anything requiring interpretation costs the reader time they do not have, and time is the thing they are minimising.
- **Layer 3 (testing).** For early careers this is genuinely mechanical — numerical and verbal reasoning under time pressure, plus a personality instrument. These are practisable and most candidates do not practise. For investment roles, expect technical questions on accounting, valuation and LBO mechanics, and structured competency questions.
- **Layer 4 (the call).** The consultant is answering one question: *if I put this person in front of my client, do I look good or stupid?* Everything they probe — why you want this, what you actually did on that deal, what you earn, what you would accept, when you can start — feeds that judgement.
- **Layer 5 (calibration).** Purely internal, and the reason strong candidates get told nothing. A client with a known preference for a particular bank, or a partner who dislikes career-changers, shapes the shortlist invisibly. You cannot win this layer; you can only be so obviously strong that you are hard to leave out.
- **Layer 6 (client CV review).** Dartmouth’s own Early Careers process lists this explicitly as a step. Your CV is judged again, by someone with different priorities, often against internal candidates you will never hear about.

4.5 Internal incentives — why consultants behave as they do

The last piece of the back end is the human one. Recruitment desks run on a well-documented set of incentives, and Dartmouth's own employee-review footprint is consistent with the industry pattern.

REPORTED — EMPLOYEE-REVIEW PLATFORMS AND INDUSTRY NORMS

Mechanism	How it works	Effect you will feel
The 360 desk	One consultant owns both business development (winning mandates from clients) and delivery (finding candidates). Some desks split into 180 roles — separate researchers and account managers.	Your consultant may be selling to clients half the week. Slow replies are often a diary problem, not a verdict on you.
Commission	Industry structures typically pay a percentage of billings above a threshold, often escalating in bands. Employee reviews of Dartmouth mention modest base salaries, and commission structures where meaningful upside is tied to originating the role yourself rather than merely filling it.	A consultant who <i>won</i> the mandate fights harder for it than one who inherited it. It is fair to ask, politely, "is this your client relationship?"
Activity KPIs	Calls, meetings, CV submissions, interviews arranged, client meetings booked — tracked weekly.	Some outreach exists to satisfy a metric. Not every message means a live, matched role. Ask directly: "is there a specific mandate behind this?"
Competitions and incentive trips	Dartmouth publicly advertises monthly, quarterly and annual competitions, prizes, lunch clubs and incentive trips, plus a long-term incentive plan.	Quarter-ends and year-ends are real. Pressure to close rises predictably in late March, June, September and December.
Training and tenure	Formalised training programmes, mentorship and a defined ladder from Associate to Managing Director. Reviews describe fast progression and strong L&D alongside long hours and intensity; roughly two-thirds of reviewers would recommend the firm.	Junior consultants may be new to your sector. Seniority correlates with client access. Working with a Principal or Director on a specialist desk is materially different from working with a first-year Associate.

READING THE INCENTIVES WITHOUT CYNICISM

None of this makes headhunters adversaries. It makes them *predictable*. A consultant who believes you are placeable, well-briefed, responsive and honest about your situation is being handed the cheapest possible route to their own target. Every piece of advice in Part VI is really the same advice: **lower the cost of representing you.**

LinkedIn: the machine that finds you

Your colleagues were not discovered by intuition. They were returned by a database query. This part explains the query — and how to be inside it.

5.1 What LinkedIn Recruiter is, and what it can see

LinkedIn Recruiter is a paid enterprise product, entirely distinct from the LinkedIn you use. Its published capabilities: search across LinkedIn’s full member base of roughly a billion profiles, more than forty filters, Boolean keyword search, saved “projects” that function as talent pipelines, bulk InMail with a monthly credit allowance, integration with the agency’s own applicant-tracking system, and “Spotlights” that re-rank results by likelihood of engagement.

REPORTED — LINKEDIN PRODUCT DOCUMENTATION AND VENDOR GUIDES

Three properties of that product matter enormously and are widely misunderstood:

- 1 It is a structured search, not a feed.** Recruiters are not scrolling and spotting you. They are constructing a query — title, location, employer, seniority, years of experience, skills, school — and receiving a ranked list. If your profile does not satisfy the filters, you do not exist for that search. There is no partial credit.
- 2 Roughly nine in ten Recruiter searches use the job-title field.** Your current and past *job titles* are the highest-leverage text on your entire profile. A brilliant “About” section cannot rescue a title field that says “Intern” with no context.
- 3 InMail is metered.** Recruiter seats come with a fixed monthly credit allowance, and credits are typically returned when a candidate responds. That creates a real, quantifiable incentive to message people likely to reply — which is exactly what Spotlights are for, and why the “open to work” and recency signals in §5.5 are worth more than they appear.

5.2 The search funnel, and where you get eliminated



Figure 10 — From a billion profiles to your inbox. Each band is a filter you either pass or fail on a single profile field. The last two bands are where identical candidates diverge. **REPORTED MECHANICS**

5.3 The Boolean strings they are running for you

Below are reconstructions of the kind of searches a Dartmouth consultant would run for four common mandates. They are illustrative, not exfiltrated — but they are built from the documented filter set and from the screening criteria London buy-side recruiters are reported to apply. Read them as a specification for your own profile. **ILLUSTRATIVE RECONSTRUCTIONS**

A. EARLY CAREERS — GRADUATE PIPELINE FOR A BANK OR FUND

```
FILTERS
  Location:      Greater London OR United Kingdom
  Schools:      [target university list]
  Years experience: less than 1
KEYWORDS / TITLE
  ("Summer Analyst" OR "Summer Intern" OR "Spring Week" OR "Spring Insight"
   OR "Off-Cycle Analyst" OR "Investment Banking Intern" OR "Penultimate Year")
  AND ("Investment Banking" OR "M&A" OR "Private Equity" OR "Asset Management"
       OR "Equity Research" OR "Leveraged Finance")
  NOT ("Recruiter" OR "Talent Acquisition" OR "Career Coach")
```

What this punishes: a profile whose current position reads only “Intern” with no discipline, no firm linked, and no location set. *What it rewards:* the exact vocabulary of the market — “Summer Analyst”, “Off-Cycle”, “Penultimate Year” — written where a title filter can read it.

B. PRIVATE EQUITY ASSOCIATE — THE CLASSIC BANKER-TO-BUY-SIDE SEARCH

```
FILTERS
  Location:      Greater London
  Years in current company: 1 - 3
  Current company: [list of 25-40 named banks and advisory boutiques]
  Seniority:      Entry / Associate
TITLE
  ("Analyst" OR "Investment Banking Analyst" OR "Associate")
KEYWORDS
  ("LBO" OR "leveraged buyout" OR "sell-side" OR "buy-side" OR "due diligence")
```

```
OR "financial modelling" OR "valuation")
AND ("German" OR "French" OR "Italian" OR "Spanish" OR "Nordic") ← the tiebreak filter
```

The language filter is not decorative. London desks cover continental Europe, and where two candidates are equal, the one with a useful second European language is reported to win more or less every time. If you speak one, it belongs in the Languages section *and* in your profile text, because the two are searched differently.

C. CREDIT / DIRECT LENDING

```
TITLE ("Analyst" OR "Associate" OR "Vice President")
KEYWORDS ("leveraged finance" OR "LevFin" OR "direct lending" OR "private credit"
          OR "restructuring" OR "unitranche" OR "credit analysis" OR "covenant")
FILTERS Location: Greater London · Years experience: 1-6
```

D. FINANCE INTO FUNDS — THE QUALIFIED-ACCOUNTANT ROUTE

```
KEYWORDS ("ACA" OR "ACCA" OR "CIMA" OR "Chartered Accountant")
AND ("financial services" OR "asset management" OR "private equity"
     OR "fund accounting" OR "fund administration" OR "audit")
FILTERS Current company: [Big Four + fund administrators] · Location: London
```

THE GENERAL RULE THESE ALL SHARE

Recruiters search in **the market's own vocabulary**, not yours. Every piece of jargon you replace with a plain-English paraphrase makes you invisible to one more search. Write “M&A” *and* “Mergers & Acquisitions”; “LBO” *and* “leveraged buyout”; “Summer Analyst” *and* “internship”. Redundancy costs you nothing and buys you coverage across differently-worded queries.

5.4 Field-by-field profile rebuild

Work through these in order. The first six are worth more than everything else combined, because they are the fields the filters actually read.

Field	Weight	What to do
Current job title	Critical	Use the market's exact title, not your firm's internal one. "Summer Analyst, Investment Banking (M&A)" beats "Intern". If your firm gave you an odd title, put the real one first and the internal one in the role description.
Company	Critical	Select the official LinkedIn company page from the dropdown so you are linked to the entity. A free-text employer name is invisible to the "current company" filter — one of the most common and most costly profile errors.
Location	Critical	Set it to the city where you want to work, not your parental home town. A blank or mismatched location fails the first filter in almost every search. If you are a student intending to work in London, say London.
Headline	Very high	220 characters, highest search weight of any free text, and the only line that travels with you into search results. Format: <i>Role/Trajectory · Firm or Field · Specialism · Distinguishing fact</i> . Front-load the keywords; mobile truncates.
Dates & employment type	High	Exact months. "Years of experience" and "years in current company" are filters computed from your dates; vague dates put you in the wrong bucket or none at all.
Education	High	University selected from the dropdown (so the school filter finds you), degree, subject, dates, and your grade or predicted grade if it is competitive. UK finance recruiters still ask about A-levels at junior level — if yours are strong, they belong on the CV and are worth a line in the education entry.
Skills	High	A searchable keyword list. Fill it with market terms: Financial Modelling, Valuation, LBO Modelling, DCF, Due Diligence, Excel, PowerPoint, Bloomberg, Capital IQ, Python if genuine. Pin the five that matter most.
About	Medium	The first ~220 characters carry the weight. Two or three sentences: what you do, what you are building toward, what you want next. Then a short keyword-dense paragraph. No third-person prose, no manifesto.
Role descriptions	Medium	Three or four bullets per role, each with a verb, a specific artefact and a number. "Built a three-statement model for a £120m carve-out" not "assisted the team with financial analysis".
Languages	Medium	Populate honestly with proficiency level. This is a genuine tiebreak filter on London desks covering Europe.
Certifications	Medium	CFA Level I candidate, ACA progress, financial-modelling certificates. Real signals of intent for career-changers.
Photo & banner	Low for search, high for reply	No effect on whether you are returned; large effect on whether the consultant clicks and messages. A plain, well-lit, professional headshot is table stakes.
Custom URL & contact info	Low	Clean vanity URL. Add an email address you actually check to your contact info — some consultants will email rather than spend an InMail credit.
Recommendations	Low	Two or three from managers who supervised real work. They are read at the click stage, not the search stage.

HEADLINE FORMULAS THAT WORK FOR SOMEONE IN YOUR POSITION

Penultimate-year student, targeting IB:

Penultimate Year Economics @ [University] · Incoming Summer Analyst, Investment Banking @ [Firm] · M&A · Financial Modelling · Seeking 2027 Graduate Analyst roles

Current intern, targeting a return offer plus options:

Summer Analyst, Investment Banking (M&A) @ [Firm] · Leveraged Finance & Valuation · Fluent German · London

Graduate, targeting the buy-side in 18 months:

Investment Banking Analyst @ [Firm] · Sponsors / M&A · LBO & Financial Modelling · Interested in Private Equity & Private Credit · London

THREE THINGS NOT TO DO

Do not keyword-stuff. A headline reading “PE | IB | M&A | LBO | DCF | VC | HF | Finance | Analyst” reads as desperate to the human who opens it, and the human is the one who decides to message you. Keywords must sit inside real sentences.

Do not claim titles you do not hold. Recruiters verify, clients verify, and inflated deal involvement is the single most-cited reason a headhunter drops a candidate permanently. Anything on your profile is fair game in an interview.

Do not put “#OpenToWork” on your photo if you are currently employed or interning. Use the recruiter-only setting instead — same signal to the people who matter, no signal to your current employer.

5.5 Spotlights: the second-order signals

Spotlights are LinkedIn’s way of telling a recruiter which of the two hundred people in their result list are most likely to reply. They re-rank the list you are already in. Four of them are directly actionable.

CONFIRMED — LINKEDIN RECRUITER DOCUMENTATION

Spotlight	What triggers it	Your move
Open to Work	You privately told LinkedIn you are open to hearing from recruiters, and shared your career interests with Recruiter users.	Turn it on, set to <i>recruiters only</i> . Fill in target titles, locations and start date — those feed the filters too. This is the highest-return single click on the platform.
Active Talent	Recent profile updates, a CV shared with recruiters, or unusually long tenure in a current role relative to peers.	Make a small, genuine profile edit every few weeks during an active search. Upload a CV where LinkedIn offers to store one for recruiters.
Have Company Connections	You are a first-degree connection of someone at the searching organisation.	Connect with Dartmouth consultants on the desks relevant to you — with a one-line note, not a bare request. This literally re-ranks you in their searches.
Interested in Your Company	You follow the company page, or you liked, shared or commented on its posts.	Follow Dartmouth Partners. Engage occasionally and substantively with their compensation reports and market posts. Low effort, real signal.
Rediscovered Candidates	Prior InMail, a saved project, a past application, or an existing record in the firm's ATS linked to Recruiter.	This is the payoff for registering properly and replying to old outreach. Once you are in their system, you resurface in every future search.
Applicants / Internal	Applied to a job posted through the project; or an existing employee flagged for internal mobility.	Applying to their live board puts you in the applicant spotlight for that mandate — a small but real boost.

THE COMPOUNDING PLAY

Individually each spotlight is a nudge. Stacked, they are decisive. A candidate who is *open to work (recruiters only)*, *recently active*, *connected to two Dartmouth consultants*, *following the company page* and *already in their ATS from a registration six months ago* will surface at or near the top of a result list containing hundreds of technically-equivalent people. That is not luck. That is five deliberate settings.

5.6 Before and after

The same person, the same experience, two profiles. The left-hand version appears in perhaps one of the four searches in §5.3. The right-hand version appears in all four and ranks near the top of two.

Field	Typical (invisible)	Rebuilt (findable)
Headline	<i>"Student at University of Nottingham Aspiring finance professional"</i>	<i>"Penultimate Year Economics @ Nottingham · Summer Analyst, Investment Banking (M&A) @ [Firm] · Financial Modelling & Valuation · Fluent French · London"</i>
Current role title	"Intern"	"Summer Analyst — Investment Banking, M&A"
Company	Typed as free text, unlinked	Selected from the dropdown, logo showing, so the company filter finds it
Location	Blank, or home town	London, United Kingdom
Dates	"2026"	"June 2026 – August 2026", employment type: Internship
Description	"Gained exposure to various aspects of the business and developed my skills."	"Built a three-statement operating model and DCF for a £200m consumer target; drafted two sections of a sell-side information memorandum; ran comparable-company and precedent-transaction analysis across 14 comparables."
Skills	"Teamwork, Communication, Microsoft Office"	"Financial Modelling · Valuation · DCF · LBO Modelling · Comparable Company Analysis · Due Diligence · Excel · Capital IQ"
Education	University typed as text, no grade	Selected from dropdown; BSc Economics; predicted First; A-levels A*A*A listed on CV
Settings	Nothing enabled	Open to Work (recruiters only) with target titles and London set; CV stored for recruiters; following Dartmouth Partners; connected to two consultants on relevant desks

A CALIBRATION POINT

None of this fabricates anything. Every entry on the right is the same summer, described in the vocabulary the search engine and the reader both use. The gap between the two columns is not experience. It is **legibility** — and legibility is the product recruiters are selling to their clients.

The candidate playbook

Everything above turned into an ordered sequence of things to do, in the order to do them.

6.1 Getting into the database on purpose

Being findable on LinkedIn gets you into channel #2. Being *in the database* gets you into channel #1 — the one they search first, and the one that persists whether or not a particular consultant ever sees your profile. There are four doors, and they are not equivalent.

- 1 **Register your CV through their portal.** Dartmouth operates a “register your CV” route through their AppTracker system. This creates the record that stages 4 and 12 of the pipeline depend on. Upload a clean, one-page, PDF CV named `Firstname-Lastname-CV.pdf`. Do this even when you are not looking — especially when you are not looking.
- 2 **Apply to one genuinely relevant live role.** Their board carries a few dozen open roles across sectors and cities. An application attaches you to a specific consultant and a specific mandate, and puts you in the Applicant spotlight. Applying to eight unrelated roles does the opposite: it tags you as unfocused.
- 3 **Email the right desk directly, once, well.** Sector inboxes are published (Appendix A). A good email is six lines: who you are and where, what you have done in one sentence with a number in it, what you are targeting and by when, your salary reality if relevant, CV attached, and a specific ask. Do not attach a cover letter. Do not email eleven desks.
- 4 **Turn up to something.** Events and campus programmes are candidate-acquisition channels — which is precisely why attending puts you in the system with a human association attached. See §6.5.

TEMPLATE: THE COLD EMAIL THAT GETS A REPLY

Subject: Summer Analyst (IB, M&A) at [Firm] – 2027 graduate roles, London

Hi [Name],

I'm a penultimate-year Economics student at [University], currently a Summer Analyst in Investment Banking (M&A) at [Firm], where I've built models on two live sell-side processes. Predicted First; A*A*A at A-level; fluent French.

I'm targeting 2027 graduate analyst roles in M&A or leveraged finance in London, and would eventually like to move to the buy-side. CV attached.

Could I have 15 minutes at some point to understand which of those routes you see most demand in? Happy to work around your diary.

[Name] · [phone] · [LinkedIn URL]

Why it works: it is short, it is specific, it contains every token a consultant needs to categorise you in ten seconds (stage, firm, discipline, grades, language, target, timing, geography), and the ask is cheap to say yes to.

6.2 The screening call: what is being scored

The twenty to forty-five minute call — whether it is framed as a “quick chat”, a coffee or a formal registration meeting — is the most consequential conversation you will have with any agency, because the notes taken during it define how you are represented for years. Reported practice across London buy-side headhunters is consistent: this is a first-round interview wearing casual clothes. **REPORTED**

What they ask	What they are actually scoring
“Walk me through your CV.”	Can you structure ninety seconds under mild pressure? Bankers who ramble here get marked down instantly, because clients will hear the same ramble.
“Tell me about a deal you worked on.”	Ownership and depth. What <i>you</i> built, the size, the sector, the outcome, the mechanics. Vagueness reads as either inexperience or exaggeration; both are fatal.
“Why do you want to move / why this sector?”	Whether your story survives a partner asking the same question. “I want more ownership and a longer-term view on assets” is a story. “PE is the natural next step” is not.
“What are you earning, and what are you looking for?”	Placeability. If your expectation is outside the client’s band, you are unsellable regardless of quality. Give a real number and a real range.
“What else are you looking at?”	Two things: competitive urgency, and whether another agency already owns an introduction to a fund they were about to submit you to. Answer honestly.
“What sort of fund appeals — large-cap, mid-market, growth?”	Market literacy. Knowing the difference, and having a reasoned preference, separates you from the majority who say “I’m open to anything.”
“When could you start?”	Notice period, visa status, exam commitments, and whether you are a real candidate or a browser.
Anything about grades, A-levels, university	UK finance screening still uses these as hard filters at junior level, and the consultant needs to know whether you clear each client’s bar before spending a submission on you.

THE FIVE THINGS TO SAY IN EVERY SCREENING CALL

1. A crisp ninety-second narrative, rehearsed out loud, ending in what you want next.
2. One deal or project described with a number, your specific contribution, and what you learned.
3. A reasoned preference — a fund size, a sector, a geography — with a reason attached.
4. Your true compensation and your true minimum, stated without embarrassment.
5. An honest map of your other processes, and a direct question: “based on what I’ve told you, where do you see me being competitive, and what should I fix?” Consultants answer that question properly, and it is worth more than any online guide.

6.3 Tiering — the uncomfortable truth

Headhunters sort candidates. Not formally, not published, but consistently: the strongest are shown the best mandates first, and everyone else is shown what remains. Reported practice in London is that this sorting happens fast, largely on the first call, and that it is durable.

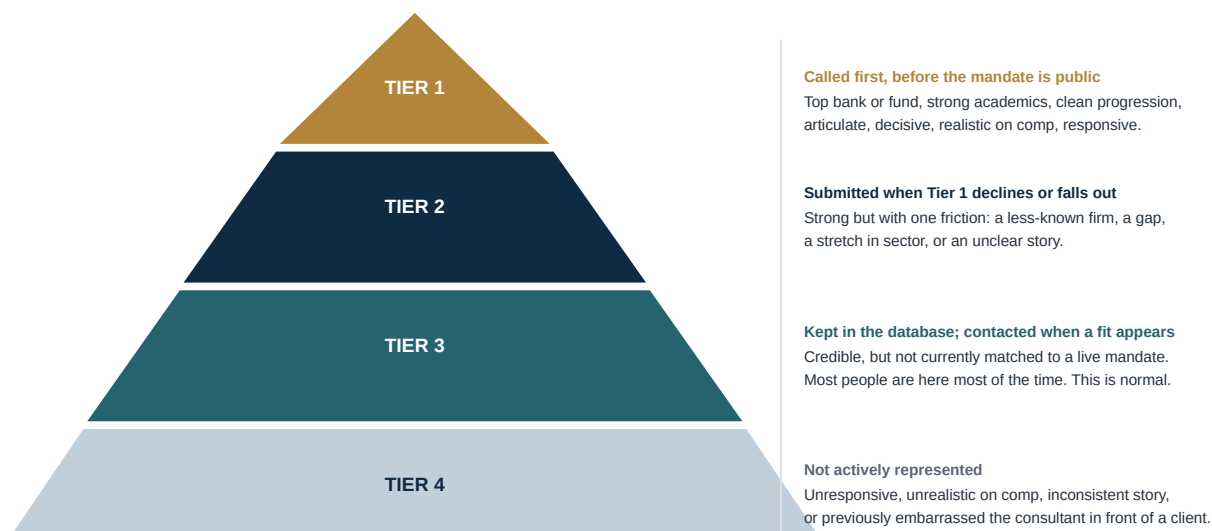


Figure 11 — How you are sorted, and what moves you. Tier is not a judgement of your worth; it is a prediction of your placement probability against *currently open* mandates. It changes when your circumstances change — which is why telling them about a promotion matters. **INFERRED MODEL, CONSISTENT WITH REPORTED PRACTICE**

Three things actually move you up a tier, and none of them is charm:

- **A change in your objective facts** — promotion, a marquee deal closing, a qualification passed, a language reaching fluency, a move to a better-regarded firm. Tell them when it happens; records go stale silently.
- **Demonstrated market realism.** Candidates who know what they are worth and what they will accept are cheap to place. Candidates chasing a number the market does not pay are expensive, and get quietly deprioritised without ever being told why.
- **Reliability.** Turning up, replying fast, not pulling out late, not renegotiating after accepting. One late withdrawal costs a consultant a client relationship, and they remember for years.

6.4 The London hiring calendar

London is not New York. US private-equity “on-cycle” recruiting compresses an entire year of associate hiring into a frantic few days, driven by headhunter datasheets and pre-scheduled interview weekends. London does not work that way. Buy-side hiring here is reported to be **off-cycle**: mandates open when someone resigns or a fund raises, processes run from three days to six weeks, and interviews typically happen three to four months before a start date. There are dense windows rather than a single starting gun. **REPORTED**

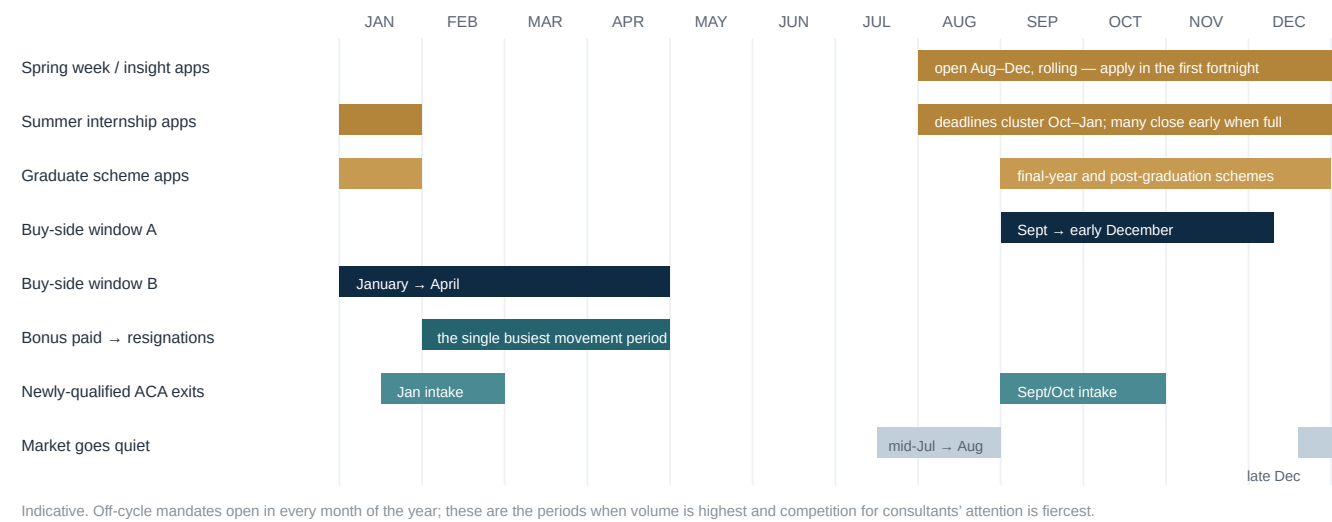


Figure 12 — The rhythm of the London year. The strategic implication: make contact in the *trough* (May–July, or late December) when consultants have time to talk properly, so that you are already a known, tiered record when the peak arrives. **REPORTED WINDOWS**

INTERPRETATION

6.5 Events, foundations and side doors

Dartmouth runs a genuine and unusually large programme of candidate-facing activity. Each item is both a real service and a front door into the database. Use them in that spirit. **CONFIRMED**

Programme	What it is	Who should use it
Women in Private Equity	An industry-first event launched in 2014, now a global breakfast series aimed at women in the early stages of their careers — typically up to five years' experience — or looking to move into PE. Recent editions have run across London, Frankfurt, Milan and Madrid, with a broader Women in Private Markets series alongside.	Early-career women targeting the buy-side. Direct access to PE professionals plus the consultants who staff those funds.
Classroom to Boardroom Foundation	Their charitable arm, focused on socio-economic access: insight days with employers, CV and cover-letter sessions, realistic interview practice, and a student mentoring network.	Students, particularly those without family or school networks in finance. Genuine value, and it puts a human association on your record.
Campus programmes	Partnerships with universities; the Early Careers team engages with students on campus annually, feeding the buy-side desks later.	Anyone at a partner university — find out whether yours is one.
Work experience	Programmes from one day to two weeks combining workshops, insight sessions and on-the-job learning, across start-ups, corporates and financial services.	Students with no formal internship yet. Low barrier, real signal.
Compensation reports	Published research across PE, credit, infrastructure, equities and multi-asset, investment banking and early careers — the Early Careers 2025 edition drew on 348+ candidates and clients; the equities guide on 600+ investment professionals.	Everyone. Download them: they are free, specific, and they let you negotiate and target with real numbers. Downloading also puts you in the system, which is the point — and is fine.

6.6 Running a multi-agency strategy without getting burned

Dartmouth holds some mandates. It does not hold most. London buy-side coverage is split across a cluster of firms, allocated fund by fund, and reshuffled regularly as relationships and consultants move. Practitioner forums are the only public source for who covers whom, and they are crowd-sourced, partial and quickly dated — treat any coverage list, including the one below, as a starting hypothesis to verify, never as fact. **REPORTED, UNVERIFIED, TIME-SENSITIVE**

Firm	Reported positioning in London
Dartmouth Partners	Strong in investment banking and increasingly in buy-side coverage; broad across credit, CFO, IR and early careers. Reported to work with names including CD&R, Bridgepoint, Nordic Capital, Advent, Investcorp, PAI, Terra Firma and Searchlight at various times. Uniquely deep at the early-career end.
KEA Consultants	Consistently named alongside Dartmouth and Blackwood as handling the bulk of mega-fund PE hiring in London.
Blackwood	Buy-side focused; frequently named for large-cap PE mandates.
PER (Private Equity Recruitment)	Long-established buy-side specialist across PE and infrastructure.
Walker Hamill	Long-standing PE and PE-backed finance recruiter.
Arkesden Partners	Buy-side and alternatives search: PE, credit, infrastructure, energy, real estate and renewables, with mandates across Europe, North America and the Middle East.
Altus Partners	Buy-side and private markets search.

THE RULES OF ENGAGEMENT

- **Work with three to five firms, not one and not fifteen.** Below three you miss most of the market; above five you lose control of who is submitting you where.
- **Never let anyone submit you without naming the client first.** Say this once, politely, at the start: *“happy to work together — I just need to approve each submission by name before it goes.”* This is your right, it is regulatory good practice, and it prevents the single worst outcome in agency recruitment.
- **Duplicate submissions kill candidacies.** If two agencies send you to the same fund, the fund may drop you entirely rather than adjudicate a fee dispute. Keep a simple spreadsheet: fund, agency, date, stage.
- **Do not badmouth other agencies** to a consultant, and do not repeat what one told you about a client’s process to another. The market is small and everyone talks.
- **Apply directly where you can.** A direct application costs the fund nothing and is often welcomed — but if an agency has already introduced you, the introduction usually stands for a contractual period. Sequence matters: decide, then act.

6.7 Twelve mistakes that get you quietly deprioritised

- 1 **Treating the first call as informal.** It is the interview that sets your tier.
- 2 **Saying “I’m open to anything.”** It reads as no thesis, and a candidate with no thesis is hard to pitch.
- 3 **Inflating deal involvement.** Verified constantly; unrecoverable when caught.
- 4 **Being vague about compensation.** Makes you unpriceable, which makes you unsubmittable.
- 5 **Slow replies.** In a contingent race, a 48-hour reply can cost you the process outright.
- 6 **Going silent mid-process.** The single fastest route to Tier 4.

- 7 **Withdrawing after a final round, or accepting then reneging.** Costs the consultant a client; you will not be represented again.
- 8 **Using a counter-offer as leverage.** Legitimate to accept a counter-offer — but say so early. Discovering it at the offer stage burns the relationship.
- 9 **Emailing every desk with the same message.** Marks you as unfocused before anyone has read your CV.
- 10 **A CV that requires interpretation.** One page at junior level, exact dates, grades, deal names, numbers.
- 11 **Never updating them.** A record that says “first-year analyst, 2024” in 2026 will be searched as a first-year analyst.
- 12 **Expecting them to work for you.** They work for the client. Your leverage is being the easiest strong candidate to sell — not appealing to loyalty that structurally does not exist.

Evidence, caveats and sources

What is solid, what is second-hand, and what is reconstruction — so you can weigh each claim yourself.

7.1 Confidence register

Claim area	Confidence	Basis and caveat
Corporate structure, ownership, offices, leadership, sectors, published process steps, events, foundation, compensation reports	CONFIRMED	Dartmouth's and Kernel's own published materials plus Companies House. Marketing language, but factual on structure.
Data collection, sources, sharing, retention, candidate rights, ATS name	CONFIRMED	Dartmouth's published privacy policy — a legally-drafted document, and the most reliable window into their back end.
Prohibition on charging candidates; regulator	CONFIRMED	Employment Agencies Act 1973; Conduct Regulations 2003; government guidance.
LinkedIn Recruiter filters, Boolean, Spotlights, InMail mechanics	CONFIRMED / REPORTED	LinkedIn's own Recruiter help documentation for Spotlights; vendor guides for filter counts and usage statistics, which are directionally reliable but not audited.
Fee percentages, rebate periods, payment terms	REPORTED	UK market norms from multiple independent recruitment-industry sources. Dartmouth's actual rates are confidential and client-specific.
Fund coverage lists; candidate service quality; internal culture and commission commentary	REPORTED	Practitioner forums and employee-review platforms. Anonymous, self-selecting, frequently out of date, and known to skew negative. Directionally useful, individually unreliable.
Rankings and awards	REPORTED	Third-party lists with their own methodologies and, in some cases, commercial dimensions.
Revenue and headcount from data aggregators	REPORTED	Mutually contradictory. Use Companies House filings if a real figure matters to you.
Desk economics, funnel ratios, tiering model, sourcing channel mix, Boolean reconstructions, screening-layer detail	INFERRED	Built from documented industry structure and economics, not from internal Dartmouth data. Reliable as a model of behaviour; not a claim about specific internal policy.

TWO HONEST LIMITATIONS

Forum evidence cuts both ways. Candidate forums contain both praise and sharp criticism of Dartmouth — disorganised processes, patchy feedback — as they do for every large agency. People post when angry far more than when satisfied. Do not form a view of an individual consultant from an anonymous post written three years ago.

Coverage maps decay fast. Which agency covers which fund changes as consultants move firms, often taking relationships with them. Anything you read about coverage, here or elsewhere, should be re-verified by asking the consultant directly: “*which funds do you currently work with at this level?*” They will usually answer.

7.2 Source list

PRIMARY — DARTMOUTH PARTNERS AND KERNEL GLOBAL

dartmouthpartners.com — About us · FAQs · Sectors index · Private Equity · Early Careers · Early Careers Candidates · Finance into Funds · Meet the team · Current Roles (job board) · Women in Private Equity · Classroom to Boardroom Foundation · Diversity · Privacy Policy · Early Careers Compensation Report 2025 · 2025 Credit Compensation Report · Infrastructure Compensation Report 2025 · Equities and Multi-Asset Compensation Guide · Investment Banking Compensation Report · blog posts on the Three Hills investment and Sunday Times ranking.

kernel-global.com — group overview, Dartmouth Partners brand page, leadership pages, FT1000 announcement. careers.kernel-global.com — internal careers and incentives.

PUBLIC RECORDS AND LEGISLATION

Companies House — Dartmouth Partners Limited, company no. 05974472 (registered office, SIC code, incorporation date, filing history). · Employment Agencies Act 1973. · The Conduct of Employment Agencies and Employment Businesses Regulations 2003 (SI 2003/3319), and GOV.UK guidance “Overview of the Conduct Regulations 2003”. · UK GDPR / Data Protection Act 2018 and ICO guidance on subject access.

THIRD-PARTY REPORTING

Three Hills Capital Partners investment announcement (March 2025). · Houlihan Lokey transaction note on Kernel. · Sunday Times 100 fastest-growing private companies. · Financial Times UK Leading Recruiters and FT1000 rankings. · eFinancialCareers Ideal Recruiter 2024–25 rankings. · Glassdoor company, salary and review pages for Dartmouth Partners. · Mergers & Inquisitions, “London Private Equity Recruiting: How to Win Offers”. · Financial Edge, “Guide to Private Equity: Headhunters”. · Wall Street Oasis forum threads on London headhunter coverage and candidate experience. · LinkedIn Talent Solutions product pages and Recruiter Help documentation on Spotlights and Boolean search. · UK recruitment-industry fee surveys and agency-fee guides (2026).

HOW TO KEEP THIS CURRENT

Three checks, twice a year, will keep everything in this guide accurate for you personally: re-read Dartmouth’s *Meet the team* page to see who now runs your desk; download whichever compensation report covers your target sector; and ask any consultant you speak to which funds they are currently mandated on. Those three inputs beat any static coverage list.

Appendix A — Contact directory

Route	Detail
Head office	125 London Wall, London EC2Y 5AS — +44 (0)20 3696 0700
General enquiries	info@dartmouthpartners.com
Early Careers desk	earlycareers@dartmouthpartners.com — your registration point as a student or intern
Private Equity desk	privateequity@dartmouthpartners.com
Finance into Funds desk	fundfinance@dartmouthpartners.com
Other desks	Each sector page on dartmouthpartners.com publishes its own inbox and names its consultants. Read the page and write to the desk, not the switchboard. Do not guess addresses.
Register your CV	The “register your CV” form linked from their candidate pages, hosted on their AppTracker system (trkr.app). This is the action that creates your database record.
Live roles	dartmouthpartners.com/jobs — filterable by sector, location, work type and salary. A US-focused board sits at /us/jobs.
Data protection	privacy@dartmouthpartners.com or privacy@kernel-global.com; postal: Data Protection, Dartmouth Partners Limited, 125 London Wall, London EC2Y 5AS
Other offices	New York (opened 2021), Charlotte NC (2023), Hong Kong
Group	kernel-global.com — Kernel Global, parent of Dartmouth Partners, Pure Search and Catalyst Partners

Appendix B — LinkedIn audit checklist

Print this. Open your profile. Work down the list. Anything unticked is a search you are currently invisible to.

FINDABILITY — THE FILTER FIELDS

- ☐ Location is set to the city I want to work in, not my home town
- ☐ Current employer is selected from the dropdown and shows the company logo
- ☐ Current job title uses the market’s vocabulary (“Summer Analyst, Investment Banking”, not “Intern”)
- ☐ Every role has exact start and end months, and an employment type
- ☐ University is selected from the dropdown; degree, subject and grade are filled in
- ☐ Headline front-loads role, field, specialism and one distinguishing fact within 220 characters
- ☐ Skills list contains at least ten market keywords, with the top five pinned
- ☐ Both the abbreviation and the full form of key jargon appear somewhere (M&A / Mergers and Acquisitions; LBO / leveraged buyout)
- ☐ Languages section is populated with proficiency levels
- ☐ Certifications include anything in progress (CFA Level I candidate, ACA)

RANK — THE SPOTLIGHT SIGNALS

- ☐ “Open to work” is on, set to **recruiters only**
- ☐ Career interests specify target titles, London, and an availability date
- ☐ A current CV is stored where LinkedIn offers to share it with recruiters
- ☐ I have made a genuine profile edit in the last three weeks
- ☐ I follow Dartmouth Partners’ company page
- ☐ I am connected to at least two consultants on the desks relevant to me
- ☐ I have engaged substantively with at least one of their posts or reports

CONVERSION — WHAT HAPPENS AFTER THEY CLICK

- ☐ Professional headshot, plain background, good light
- ☐ About section: first two sentences say what I do and what I want next
- ☐ Every role has three or four bullets, each with a verb, an artefact and a number
- ☐ Two recommendations from people who supervised real work
- ☐ Custom URL claimed; a monitored email address is in my contact info
- ☐ Nothing on the profile is exaggerated to a degree I could not defend in an interview

BEYOND LINKEDIN

- ☐ Registered directly through Dartmouth’s CV portal
- ☐ Applied to one genuinely relevant live role on their board
- ☐ Emailed the single correct desk with a six-line, specific message
- ☐ Downloaded the compensation report for my target sector

- ☐ Registered for one relevant event
- ☐ Repeated the above for three to five other agencies
- ☐ Diary reminder set: update every agency the day my role, title or qualification changes

Appendix C — Screening-call prep sheet

Fill this in before any first call with any headhunter. Keep it to one page and keep it in front of you during the call.

Prompt	Your answer (write it out, then say it aloud twice)
Ninety-second walkthrough School → university → why finance → current role → what next	
Deal or project one Size, sector, your specific contribution, outcome, what you learned	
Deal or project two	
Why this sector, in one sentence with a reason attached	
Preference and rationale Fund size / strategy / geography, and why	
Compensation Current base, bonus, and the minimum you would genuinely accept	
Availability Notice period, visa status, exams, earliest start	
Other processes Firm, stage, which agency introduced you	
Your three questions for them Suggested: which funds are you mandated on at my level? Where am I competitive, and where am I not? What should I fix before you put me forward?	

Appendix D — Subject Access Request template

Send by email. They must normally respond within one month. You do not need to give a reason, and there is no fee. Attach photo ID only if they ask for it.

To: `privacy@dartmouthpartners.com`
Cc: `privacy@kernel-global.com`
Subject: Subject Access Request — [Your Full Name], DOB [dd/mm/yyyy]

Dear Data Protection team,

I am making a subject access request under Article 15 of the UK GDPR for a copy of all personal data you hold about me.

My details: Full name: [] Date of birth: []
Email addresses you may hold for me: []
Telephone: [] Approximate dates of contact: []

Please include, so far as they constitute my personal data:

1. All records held about me in your CRM / applicant tracking system, including consultant notes, categorisations, tags and ratings.
2. My CV(s) and any versions you have amended or reformatted.
3. A record of the roles and clients I have been submitted to, and the dates of those submissions.
4. Any assessment or test results held about me.
5. Correspondence about me between members of your staff.
6. The source(s) from which you obtained my personal data, where it was not provided by me directly.
7. The categories of recipients to whom my data has been disclosed, including any other Kernel Group companies.
8. Your retention period, or the criteria used to determine it.

Please provide the response in a commonly used electronic format.

If you consider any part of this request to require clarification, please contact me promptly rather than delaying the response as a whole.

Kind regards,
[Name] · [email] · [phone]

Note: they may lawfully withhold or redact material that would disclose the personal data of others, including client identities, and certain confidential references. A partial response is normal; a non-response is not, and can be escalated to the Information Commissioner's Office.

Appendix E — Competitor map and submission tracker

Use the left table to plan coverage; use the right-hand template to prevent the duplicate submissions that end candidacies.

Agency	Registered?	Consultant	Notes / which funds they say they cover at my level
Dartmouth Partners			
KEA Consultants			
Blackwood			
PER			
Walker Hamill			
Arkesden Partners			
Altus Partners			

Client / fund	Introduced by	Date	Stage / outcome

Appendix F — Glossary

ATS / CRM. Applicant tracking system / candidate relationship management — the database where your record lives. Dartmouth's is called AppTracker.

Buy-side. Firms that invest capital — PE funds, credit funds, hedge funds, asset managers. As opposed to the sell-side (banks and advisers).

Contingent search. No placement, no fee. The dominant model at junior and mid level, and the source of most recruiter behaviour.

Datasheet. A standardised candidate summary a headhunter compiles — background, grades, deals, preferences — and circulates to clients. Central to US on-cycle; used less formally in London.

Desk. A team covering one sector or niche. Dartmouth publishes eleven.

Employment agency vs employment business. Legal distinction: an agency introduces candidates for permanent roles; an employment business supplies temporary workers it pays itself. Different obligations apply.

Exclusivity. A client commitment to use one agency for a search — usually accompanying a retained fee.

InMail. LinkedIn's paid direct message to someone you are not connected to. Metered, which is why recruiters target likely responders.

Longlist / shortlist. Everyone plausible (dozens to hundreds) versus the three to six CVs actually submitted to the client.

Mandate. An instruction from a client to fill a role. Everything in an agency revolves around live mandates.

Market map. A systematic list of every person at every relevant firm who could do the job — the research artefact underpinning a search.

Off-cycle. Hiring that happens whenever a seat opens, rather than in a synchronised annual process. The London norm on the buy-side.

On-cycle. The compressed, synchronised US private-equity associate recruiting process.

PSL. Preferred supplier list — the small set of agencies a large client permits to work on its roles.

Rebate / clawback. Contractual refund of part of the fee if the placed candidate leaves within a defined window, typically 8–12 weeks.

Retained search. Fee paid in instalments regardless of outcome, in exchange for exclusivity and a committed process.

Spotlight. A LinkedIn Recruiter re-ranking signal — open to work, recently active, connected to the firm, following it, or previously in its ATS.

360 / 180 desk. Whether one consultant does both business development and candidate delivery (360), or the two are split between specialists (180).

SAR. Subject access request — your statutory right to obtain the personal data an organisation holds about you.

About this document. Compiled 23 August 2026 from publicly available sources. Independent research, not affiliated with or endorsed by Dartmouth Partners, Kernel Global, or any firm named. Details change — consultants move, coverage shifts, product features evolve — so verify anything you intend to act on materially. Nothing here is legal, career or financial advice.